

In the shadow of a volcano

The ancient city walls of Pompeii run for about 2 miles (3 km) around the archaeological site. A modern town, Pompei, has sprung up nearby. Mount Vesuvius, the volcano whose eruption destroyed the Roman city, looms above the ruins. It has erupted many times since the destruction of Pompeii and no one knows when it might do so again.

1 City limits

Pompeii had a perimeter wall to control access to the city.

2 Grid plan

Many Roman cities were planned on grids, with the roads crossing each other at right angles.

The eruption of Vesuvius

A young scholar called Pliny the Younger watched the eruption of Vesuvius. His eyewitness account inspired later artists, such as Pierre-Jacques Volaire, who painted this dramatic image.

